love without measure

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

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by dead_frog

Summary

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When Prime had picked the venue, some sick relief had filled her. Did she always have one foot out of the door? Clearly so. Now she's run off like a coward. He's waiting at the altar whilst she's on the stoop of Adora's home.

Catra's knuckle rattles against the door, and now everything's set in stone. No return.

-

catra escapes her wedding to the safety of adora's home

Notes

title from free treasure by adrianne lenker :)

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The door swings open.

Adora's face runs through millions of expressions. Confusion, surprise, stress, sadness. Catra watches as Adora filters through them all, then steps aside and gestures Catra in.

"Are you safe?"

The first question Adora asks. Catra doesn't know how to answer. No one followed her, she made *sure* of it. But she hasn't felt safe in months. Catra's silent, breathing shallow whilst Adora assesses her. The bruises aren't visible at least.

"Can I give you a physical?"

Second question. Catra doesn't want to be inspected. This is something she can respond to.

"No," Catra's voice is quiet. Part of her wonders when she lost the strength. All her energy is drained, or maybe it was never there to begin with.

"Okay," Adora says. Catra's eyes water in relief, and Adora reaches for her shoulder. A test, to see if touch is okay. Catra walks into

Adora's arms, and those strong arms wrap around her. Safe, finally. Adora rubs Catra's back, "Do you want to get changed?" Words aren't forming, so she nods. Adora leads her to the bedroom, "this is a long sleeve, it'll be tighter, and you can wear this baggy top on top or instead. Bra and underwear, I also have boxers, so I'll leave them out. These sweatpants should fit well." Adora holds up everything, checking for any sign of disapproval in Catra. But it doesn't matter, anything is better than this dress, "you can have a shower if you need," Catra shakes her head no. The thought of undressing alone makes her stomach twist. Adora nods and passes a towel so she can dry off, "I'll let you change-" Adora goes to leave but Catra grabs her hand. She can't undo the corset alone, not without ruining it.

What is she trying to preserve?

Still, she guides Adora's hands to her back, where the laces are tightly wound. Adora's eyes widened, "do you want me to undo this?" Careful, making sure she gets consent for everything. Catra needs it, even if verbalising her replies feels impossible. Finally, she nods, and Adora's hands turn to make quick work. Where *his* hands were supposed to be by the end of the night, undoing this before taking her, as he always had. It wasn't going to be anything special, it wasn't their first time. She was always his to use.

Still, once the bust is undone, Catra chokes on a sob.

"I can stay if you need," Adora says, "but I can leave too." Options. Catra has to speak.

"Stay," Catra says, the word wavering in the air.

"I'll look away-" Adora's words are cut off when Catra takes off the corset too soon. Bruises across her ribs, on display. Not the ones he gives, rather inflicted from the tightness of the corset. At least these she can blame herself for, "sorry. I'll face the wall," Adora says, turning away quickly. Catra sobs as the dress drops to the floor. The lingerie underneath burns into her skin. Splitting, lace

tearing, threads ripping apart. Scraps of intricate fabric, torn in her hands. Floats to the floor as her hands let go, lands on top of the dress.

No longer his.

Boxers on, baggy t-shirt on, no long sleeve, sweatpants on. Everything fits well, not tight enough to constrict her, not so baggy she was drowning. Smells of home.

“I’m done,” Catra mumbles. Adora turns, folds what Catra isn’t wearing and slots in neatly in her dresser. Organised.

“Have you eaten?” Adora asks. Back to yes or no questions. Easy to answer.

“No,” Catra says. Technically a lie- she ate this morning. But it's 6:30 in the evening, and her stomach hurts.

“I was just about to start dinner. There’s enough for the both of us,” Adora says, walking her over to the dining room. Catra picks up the lingerie, abandons the dress in the room.

“Where’s the bin?” An actual sentence, *improvement*. Adora gestures to it and steps on a pedal, opening the lid. Catra drops the lacey garments in, watching for a moment before the lid closes. Adora walks to the stove, stirring a small pot. She grabs another bowl, serves them both. She takes sourdough bread out, butters the slices and places them on a plate. Catra helps carry it over to the dining table whilst Adora grabs the cutlery.

The first dinner Catra hasn’t said grace at in who knows how long.

She picks up the spoon, mind categorising all the ways she could defend herself with it. A sick habit, creature of violence. The taste of soup reaches her tongue and it feels like home. Her chest buzzes with warmth.

“It’s not a lot, sorry,” Adora apologises, “I made the bread myself though,” she says, and Catra reaches for a slice. Crunchy, thin

layer of crust, soft and airy on the inside. Dips into the soup, melts in her mouth. Home. It's all home.

"Thank you," Catra says belatedly, "I can go," she offers. She was overstaying her welcome the moment she came in. Adora's hand reaches across the table, pulls back when Catra flinches.

"No, please don't. I missed you."

The world processes in fragments, her bowl emptying without memory of actually eating. But once it's empty her whole body feels a forgotten warmth. She gets up, taking their bowls to the sink. She needs to be useful.

"I have a dishwasher," Adora says, gesturing to the steel box. Catra's stomach drops.

"How can I help?" She's desperate to prove her worth. Adora hesitates, and Catra recognises that internal conflict, wavering behind her eyes. Silently, Catra pleads, staring with a strength she doesn't feel. But she needs this.

"You can wipe down the counters," Adora relents, passing a dish cloth, and Catra sets to it, collecting the crumbs then spraying the surface, wiping away the excess. Careful, making multiple passes on the laminate. *No mistakes*. Adora loads the dishwasher alongside her. She sets it on when they're finished, "do you want to sleep?"

Unconscious, vulnerable.

"No," Catra decides, "what can I do about the bruises?"

"We can put a cold compress over any new ones, and a heat pack over older ones," Adora says. That means admitting to previous bruises, substantiating the pattern.

"Just a cold compress. Do you have one that can wrap around?" Catra asks. Can't admit to herself what that would mean. Pathetic.

“Yeah.” Then Adora leaves, the freezer door opening in the next room over. She returns with what Catra asked for- a long cold pack with a buckle on each side, “clip this on over your clothes. It’ll make the cold more tolerable.” Catra used to loathe instructions. Now it’s the only thing she can follow. Adora’s stress is visible, scanning over Catra- the nurse that can never quite clock out.

“How’s your job been?” Catra asks, because it’s something they can discuss.

“Busy, as usual. The patients sometimes blur together,” Adora laughs, but it’s a little forced, “do you work?”

“No.” Trapped, lured in under the guise of financial security. Lamb to the slaughter “I’m so stupid,” Catra says, the tears resurfacing. She’s only substantiating an ugly truth she refused to face. A reality she built herself, her own damn fault.

“You’re not,” Adora assures.

“You *told* me,” Catra argues. Her eyes water, eyebrows furrowing and muscles tightening. She presses her head against Adora’s shoulder, tears falling onto Adora’s top. Adora’s arms wrapped around Catra, “I should’ve listened,” Catra’s throat tightens.

“You’ve listened now,” Adora insists. Catra’s body trembles from her sobs, “that’s what matters.”

Catra doesn’t have anything to say. It doesn’t really matter, she’s just a blot on the Earth, ephemeral. She’s not important, but he made her feel that way. He treasured her, owned her. Her value was measured in the worth he placed upon her.

It was that simple. Now it’s not.

“I can’t do this,” Catra mumbles, but she already has. There’s no taking it back. She can’t unwind time or fix the past. She pulls away, Adora’s arms loosening and dropping to her sides, “I’m

underweight," she says. A physical, fixable problem. Something Adora would know how to help.

He likes her underweight, says it's classy to be skinnier. Not a problem, a standard she held herself to for him. She can't live her life for him though. Not anymore.

"Can I take your blood pressure?" Adora asks.

"Sure," Catra agrees. Adora leads her to the bathroom and reaches for the drawer under the sink, pulling out a cuff with a screen. She slides it onto Catra's arm and switches it on, watching it calibrate. It inflates, tightening around her upper arm and-

Get it off.

Fingertips dig into her thighs, pressure suffocating her. Then, the cuff deflates.

"Are you okay?" Adora asks, her voice concerned.

"Did you get the reading?" Catra doesn't want to address Adora's question, it's too open ended.

"No, you seem a bit stressed and that affects your heart rate." Adora's eyes catch on Catra's hands, "did he do that?" she asks about her blunt claws, face tugged into a frown as she picks them up. Catra drops her hand; can't let those weapons near Adora. She's erratic, untamed.

"They're dangerous," Catra murmurs. He said that whenever he'd cut them short. Always hit the nerve, never flinched when Catra did. Calculated, "it's for the best."

"They're not dangerous, they're defense," Adora comments, "you never hurt me with them."

"I can kill someone with these," Catra points out. Adora thought too highly of her, always had too much faith. Blind and deaf to Catra's analysing mind, head strategising how anything within

reach could be a weapon if needed. She doesn't need defense here, Adora is safe. Yet her mind still reflexes to violence. *Savage, just like he says.*

"But you wouldn't," Adora emphasises, like it means anything. Whatever, "did he cut your hair too?" Catra stays silent. Can't admit the control Prime has over her, just how much jurisdiction he has.

"Can you lay off?" Catra huffs out, hugging herself. Adora immediately rescinds, eyebrows pinched together.

"Sorry," she apologises. Catra shrugs, "do you wanna do anything?"

"No," Catra mumbles. Adora nods.

"Let's sit on the couch." So they do, a stiff silence lingering in the space between them, unnaturally polite, awkward. But every topic to break this discomfort is tainted with his shadow.

His reach is suffocating.

"I can't escape him," Catra whispers. Her eyes are watering, and all the detached emotions begin to retether, now a chilling understanding lingers, "he knows everything. He's seen everything. Adora-" Catra's voice disappears in a silent cry. She's forgotten who she is, left it in the distant past, "I don't have any of my stuff," Catra says, "I wasn't planning this, I just- before the ceremony…" Catra's voice trails off. There's no way she could verbalise the stress of looking into her future. The future she was supposed to seal with him, before she took off like a coward. No giant confrontation, no vengeance, just spineless escape.

"Do you want me to get your things?" Adora asks. The thought of Adora confronting Prime makes her sick. If he put her hands on her, did anything-

"No," Catra mumbles. Weak. But Adora takes her word, *listens* to what she says.

“Okay. I won’t,” Adora affirms. Catra still waits for the punchline, braces in case what she wants isn’t enough and Adora decides to disregard it. Nothing happens though, and eventually Catra turns her head to look straight ahead. The television is off, the black screen reflecting the coffee table. Round mug stains pressed into the surface, probably from sipping tea after long, restless nights. A natural domesticity. Distantly familiar. A blue blanket, slipped off from the armrest of the plush couch, bundled on the floor, “Sorry,” Adora says, rubbing the back of her neck, “between all the shifts I haven’t gotten a lot of cleaning time.” *Work*. A commitment Adora *has*.

“When’s your next shift?” Catra asks.

“Tomorrow,” Adora admits, “I’m gonna cancel it though.” Catra’s ears flatten, Adora instantly picking up on Catra’s anxiety, “it’s not just *for* you though. It’s also for me, I just want some time with you. I missed you so much.” Adora’s yearning begins to shine through, like light fluttering through the curtains. An expression muffled by time, but never forgotten. Her stare is gentle, warm like the air from their cheap heater when they roomed together in college; a moment Catra can barely remember, playing at the edges of her mind. She reaches for that balmy memory, holds that buzz to her chest and lets it dissolve there.

“I missed you too,” Catra says. It’s so much more though. The way her muscles can finally rest, loosening after so long of being taut. She's unwound, her body exhausted after being alert for so long. A tear drips from her eye, not because she’s sad but because every fibre of her being is weary, and in need of this rest. She shuffles next to Adora, pushes her head into her arms and lets go, untethering from that insistent alarm in her head, releasing her vigilance.

Soon, she’ll unencumber herself from the debris of a life she set aflame, start to build something true. For now, the safety of Adora and her home is all she needs.

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